

Siempre (Always)

Book One

Prologue

The Forest

She dragged her body over the spongy woodland floor on her stomach. Walking was not an option. She was weak, much too weak to even crawl on hands and knees. Her breathing was ragged. Her energy nearly spent. But she forced herself to keep moving. She had to. He would be coming for her, hunting her like he had been for over three centuries. Carelessness, brought on by her fiery temper, allowed him to recapture her, but she managed to escape minutes before. Would she be able to elude him again, like she had so many times in their endless lives?

The night air carried the sound of a crisp snap from a dry twig. It startled her. She stopped slithering through decaying debris on the sylvan floor to listen. A sigh of relief left her lips. *It's not him.* That's what she thought anyway, since her kind would never clumsily tramp through a forest. Her kind would never give away their location, especially when tracking prey. Human prey. Unless, he was doing it on purpose to mock her. *Was he?* She urgently willed her body to drag itself as far away from him as possible.

She heard footsteps. They were his. *That cabrón is making noise on purpose.* He was taunting her, letting her know there

would be no escape. *¡Hijo de la chingada!* How she hated him. She released another sigh. This one was filled with hopelessness. It didn't mean she was giving up. She would never do that. But in her weakened condition, escape on this night was not to be. She had not fed in days. He had starved her in his attempt to bend her will and do his bidding. Give herself willingly to him, and extract information from her which would prove devastating to the human race. But she defied him as she always had, and she always would.

She relaxed. Her long black tresses covered her face and the portion of the forest floor cushioning her head. She was so tired. Fatigue coaxed her to close her eyes. To rest. The soft cool earth felt comfortable against her body, willing her to sleep. She wanted to sleep. But she knew that she couldn't. If she did, she might not wake. Ever again. It would be the end of her ludicrously extended life.

But even if she wanted to fall asleep, to permit herself to die, he would never allow it. He would force her to feed on the sanguine fluid which flowed within the veins of humans. But only enough to keep her in a severely weakened state. Her deep, dark eyes popped opened. She heard him. He was near. Each step he took intentionally crunched the twigs and leaves scattered throughout the cushioned ground, with sharp, brittle snaps. She closed her eyes again and waited for him to find her.

A few miles away, along the shoreline of Big Bear Lake, a

handsome young man looked up at the full moon. His name was Sam Clay. Sam had spent a week with friends who introduced him to a girl which they insisted he had to meet. This one at least was charming and articulate. But like all of the others, he failed to connect with her.

He gazed at the stone-cold radiance of the lake outlined by the stoic trees that stood as they had for decades, attesting to their powerful resilience. He watched the stars twinkle brightly against a clear indigo sky. The night was enchanted, filling his soul with high spirits. A lover of life, he knew these were the moments which gave humankind the feeling of immortality, despite the fact that humans were painfully aware each of them would one day be visited by Death, the supreme vanquisher.

He skipped a flat rock over the glassy surface. The pebble hopped across the still water and sank, but not before releasing a surge of ripples fanning outward to disrupt the tranquility of the lake. Sam strolled to his gleaming silver Porsche parked in the distance. The sports car was built for speed. He opened the driver's door while he thought, *I'm a lucky guy*. Sam was. He got in and closed the door.

His was a great life with only true love missing. Sam had experienced varying degrees of it, but never the kind of love that churned your stomach and nearly forced your knees to buckle from the heat of a passionate kiss. So he did feel an emptiness whenever he saw couples who were in love. And he felt a certain

loneliness when he witnessed them professing their devotion for one another with a mere wordless glance.

Sighing longingly, Sam shrugged. *I guess I can live without it.* Could he really? If living on Earth has taught us anything, we are not the ones who select our futures. The powerful engine came to life, rumbling while it idled.

What if Sam at last found someone he absolutely could not live without? What if he was compelled to make a choice? Could he do without true love if he had to choose between it and human existence? Could he give up the family which he loved more than anything? Life, Fate, God, you choose, would soon put him to the test. As he sped away, little did Sam know that he was about to embark upon the adventure of his lifetime, with the girl he had to meet.

Chapter 1

The Girl

What would be the use of having a high-powered sports car, if you couldn't get out on the road once in a while and open it up a little? And what better place than on a curvy mountain road late at night? The glossy gray Porsche raced past. The powerful engine shattered the silent night with a throaty roar. Its xenon headlights effortlessly pierced through the darkness for several yards ahead.

Sam usually made sensible investments, but his car was the single extravagance that he allowed himself. And for one reason. Sam knew he couldn't take it with him. Life's uncertain journey was much too short for a human to deny oneself a guilty pleasure here and there along the way. So the price of an exceptionally quick sports car was acceptable.

He emitted a loud whoop of delight as the gray rocket drew close to a tight corner. The potent engine roared a series of descending low notes as Sam expertly shifted down through the gears to negotiate an approaching sharp curve. With yet another joyful whoop, he floored it for the long straightaway ahead. The high-performance engine belted out a sustaining note in a much higher register that bounced off the sturdy trunks of the forest trees with a resounding echo.

A quarter mile up ahead a long caravan of eighteen-wheelers

stretched out in front of the Porsche, anxious to demonstrate its impressive power and speed. He floored it. The silver streak roared a mighty roar and zoomed past the tractor-trailer trucks. Each time he passed one the wind created by the hurtling missile released a booming vroom! He passed another. Vroom! Then another. Vroom! And another and another and another. Vroom! Vroom! Vroom! He looked into the rearview as he passed the last of the semis and floored it.

The road and forest trees became a blur. The dotted line which separated the two lanes of the mountain road transformed into solid white. Sam expertly shifted through the gears and fed his need for speed. He affectionately squeezed the wheel with a heartfelt appreciation. The car was worth every cent he had paid for it. Sam indeed was a lucky guy and he knew it which prompted him to yell "Thank you, God!" Sam floored it again, the sports car defying anything to catch it.

Slowing to a near standstill to negotiate a hairpin turn he noticed lights moving in and out within the trees. Sam narrowed his eyes for a better look. *What the hell's that? Villagers with lanterns searching for the Frankenstein Monster?* He would later realize how close to the truth that was. Except, had he known, Sam would have preferred Frankenstein over the monster he would soon stumble upon.

His curiosity got the best of him. It always did. He pulled into a turnout and parked. He shut off the powerful engine which

reluctantly rumbled to silence. Sam's eyes followed the bobbing lights through the gaps in the forest green. They appeared and disappeared behind wooded giants like flickering Christmas tree lights. His curiosity heightened. Sam opened his car door. The glinting, gray coating reflected the light of the full moon. He stepped out.

Again he observed lights dancing in and out of the woodland trees, except now there were more of them. *Who is out there? And why?* A tingling sensation traveled the length of his spine, like a low powered electric shock. Deep within him, Sam felt he might be stepping into danger. He couldn't help it. Burning curiosity riddled his better sense, prodding him, pushing him. Sam entered the forest.

The dark woods teemed with the harmonies of birds chirping. Small padded paws thumped across the woodland floor, and large animals snorted then tore off mouthfuls of nutritious plants and undergrowth. During daylight hours, the elements of the natural world were welcomed by humans, allowing them to feel as one with nature. However, after the sun set, taking with it the warming rays of its incandescent light, the forest inevitably changed, like it had every night since time began.

Shadows, cast by sunrays raining down on enormous trees, were greeted with open arms by humans sitting under them to enjoy the coolness, while contemplating Mother Nature. But when those shadows were transformed by the luminescent moon, Earth's

sole nocturnal light source, it transformed woodlands into giant seas of obscured forest hues and ominous darkness. Consequently, human perception of the forest would change dramatically. Even the harmonious symphony of timberland creatures became menacing, posing a danger, a threat.

Sam felt this menace. He felt how the sounds of nature had been suddenly altered into a sensation of impending doom. This awareness heightened when the night air was unexpectedly filled with the distant, deep throated growl of a predator, followed by rapid flapping wings of startled birds then, absolutely nothing. The sound of silence stopped him in his tracks. Sam realized the forest was no longer his friend.

Tiny paws ran and scampered up a giant tree making Sam's heart beat faster. He looked skyward, searching then sighed with relief. Sitting on a branch, a furry-tailed squirrel stared down at him from atop its lofty perch with bright saucer-like eyes; a branch Sam wished he was sharing with the tree dweller. When the forest critters resumed their chirping, hooting and foraging, he knew it was again safe to move on.

A big rig roared past and drowned out all sound, including Sam's footsteps crunching scattered fallen leaves on the spongy forest floor. He smiled to himself. *So this is what walking on a field of Doritos Chips sounds like.* Sam's pondering unexpectedly ended when a low-hanging branch nearly collided with his head. He ducked in time and kept searching for those illusive lights,

while another semi roared past.

Unknown to Sam, the deafening sound of the eighteen-wheeler saved his life. Vampires possessed phenomenal abilities. One of them was superhuman hearing. To a vampiric, hearing a pin drop from a distance was child's play. And if the vampire hated all of humankind, an unexpected interruption while he was up to no good usually meant death for that unfortunate human.

Still another big rig bellowed past as Sam tripped, nearly falling on his hands and knees. Luckily, he regained his footing in time. He stood in one spot to allow his eyes to better adjust to the darkness. When his eyesight had acclimated to the night, Sam continued on. It was dark in the forest. It was so dark Sam toyed with the thought of turning around and walking back to his car. But his curiosity pushed him on.

As Sam reached the outskirts of a small clearing within the forest, he saw Alina leaning against a broad tree trunk. She was barely able to sit upright. Although she was obviously weak and pale, it was clearly evident that her remarkable features were beyond stunning. He was taken motionless by the effect that the young woman's presence had on him; so much so, Sam did not even ask himself what she was doing there, sitting under a tree, in the middle of a forest. He was spellbound.

She hypnotized him so much he barely noticed that her pants and long-sleeved blouse were a tad burnt. Yet, he didn't ask himself why. Sam watched the Mexican beauty defiantly look up at

someone, which allowed the moon to further accentuate her allure. Anyone guessing her age would have estimated she was two-and-half decades old. They would have been wrong. She was older, much, much older.

Sam snapped out of his trance when a hand slapped her face with such force it knocked her down sideways onto the soft dirt. She weakly struggled back to her sitting position while her eyes spewed hatred for Luther, the personification of wickedness. His pale features exuded blatant malevolence, his tall sinewy body deceptively powerful. Whatever human emotion he once possessed was gone, except for the deep love Luther had for her. Alina had always been, and would always be, his transparent vulnerability; the love of his very, very long life.

Sensing he was in the presence of a foreboding and vile creature, Sam inadvertently took a step backward. He cringed when his foot stepped on a dry twig. By sheer chance, the loud snap was swallowed by still another big rig roaring past. Sam intuitively sensed his good fortune, silently thanking his lucky stars. Cautiously, quietly, he took a step forward for a better view of the scene unfolding before him. Meantime, the thunderous echo of the passing semi bounced off the trees, gradually fading in the distance.

"Is that any way to treat a lady?"

Alina's sarcastic remark was rewarded with another vicious slap across her face. Sam winced. *Who is that dick?* He wanted to

intervene. His inner voice screamed in protest. Fortunately, Sam listened to that inner voice and kept watching.

In a rare moment of emotion, Luther's eyes moistened. He looked at her with an impassioned love, which his icy heart had harbored for over three-hundred-years. "I have waited patiently for you. Why can't you share your life with me? Why can't you love me, Alina? Why?"

Her eyes, seething in hatred and spite, burned through his. "Have you looked into a mirror lately?" Luther's terrifying evil resurfaced.

"You bitch!" He backhanded her with such force, the thick black mane, which outlined a breathtaking face, covered Alina's features entirely.

In another display of defiance, Alina flung her hair back with an insolent twist of her head. "Is that it? Is that all you've got?"

"Be careful how you speak to me." Even his voice was to be feared.

From his secret vantage point, Sam felt the effect of its wicked timbre and hollowness. It resonated with a flatness that bordered on lifelessness. It was the voice which had instilled spine melting fear in humans for uncountable centuries. Humans who had been the unfortunate ones to hear it right before they became his meal.

Hovering somewhere in the treetops, someone watched Luther

and Alina then looked away to gaze at Sam hiding amid the trees. The hovering presence observed Sam with keen interest before it returned its attention to Luther, grinning heartlessly at Alina. Her energy nearly spent, she looked to Heaven.

"God, how long must this go on?"

Luther's leer became a blood curdling chuckle. Sam felt its wickedness. He involuntarily shivered.

"Alina. You know better. He doesn't answer creatures like us."

"Speak for yourself."

Annoyed, Luther looked away. Whatever his wicked mind was thinking, his thoughts were interrupted when he became aware of the presence floating above him. He looked into the treetops. His squinting eyes searched. He saw nothing.

Meanwhile, her long, dense, black hair had worked its way back down, covering half of her face. She pushed her hair aside exposing dark, piercing eyes that all of a sudden stared at the exact spot where Sam stood in the darkness. He was startled, to say the least. He sensed she could see him, which made him feel exposed. Sam stood motionless, not knowing what to do. Then an unexpected thrill of excitement and danger coursed through his body in waves of shivering sensations.

The moment was broken when Luther returned his attention to Alina, who looked at him spitefully as she professed her hatred. "¡Eres un hijo de puta!" Sam didn't speak Spanish, and he didn't

need to. He got the general idea of what she said after she spat on Luther's shoes.

"You ungrateful bitch!" He slapped her again, not sparing an ounce of force. He looked away in scorching fury.

Sam could no longer watch this beautiful, intriguing young woman take a beating. *If I don't stop him, he's going to really hurt her.* Sam looked around and spotted a stout tree branch that he could use as a club. Though Sam was no slouch in a fight, *why take any chances?* Luther again slapped her hard. *That's it!* Sam decided to help Alina, a decision which would have proven fatal for Sam the human. He quietly picked up the short tree limb with determination.

Sam began to move, but stopped in mid-step when Alina again stared at him through the darkness. *How does she know I'm here?* Sam was puzzled but bent on saving her. He was about to complete his step when she imperceptibly shook her head. Alina's dark, brooding eyes somehow conveyed to Sam how futile his attempt to save her would be. Wisely heeding her silent advice, he returned to his hiding place among the forest trees.

Reassured Sam would not attempt to help her, Alina taunted Luther. "Go on. Put me out of my misery, which is you!"

"And bring our courtship to an end?" He turned and favored Alina with another spine-chilling grin. He was often sarcastic, especially the moment before he fed on someone. His cadaverous grin faded as his eyes bored into Alina. "You may never love me,

but you will give me what I want, or else." He glanced at the heavens theatrically to make his point.

Sam followed Luther's eyes and searched the sky. *I don't get it.* Sam continued to look skyward, trying to understand what he meant. Sam returned his attention to the scene before him. Luther also turned his cold gaze back to Alina with an eerily frightening smirk.

She scoffed. "You won't leave me here. You don't have los cajones, cabrón."

"Don't dare trifle with me, Alina!"

His boiling anger gave her pause. Alina was weak, incapable of fleeing to safety, and he knew it. Had she finally exhausted his patience? *If I don't give him what he wants, will he really leave me here to suffer the sun's unforgiving rays?* Her brief moment with insecurity faded, and was replaced with reason. She knew better. Defiantly, Alina returned his withering glare.

"Like I said, you don't have the balls, Luther!"

Luther was about to speak when he sensed another presence. Concerned, Alina furtively gave Sam a look which said hide! Sam ducked behind a tree as Luther turned in his direction. Sam's heart began to pound with a fear he had never felt. He didn't know why. Then random awareness entered his mind. The sounds of nature were non-existent. Nothing. Nothing at all. Only silence. Did the woodland creatures know something Sam didn't?

Luther gave Alina a grin that would have made even the most

formidable human male on Earth drop to his knees, quaking with fear. Alina had seen it before. That smile was usually followed by brutal death. Had Sam not been hiding behind a tree, he would have seen Luther tugging at his shirt in rhythm, to simulate a beating heart. *Thump-thump. Thump-thump. Thump-thump.* Sam would have known it was his pounding heart Luther could hear. There was absolutely nothing Alina could do to stop The Dark Ancient One.

Sam sneaked a quick look as Luther began to take a step in his direction. The fear he felt accelerated. He gripped the tree branch he held with both hands. He wasn't going down without a fight. *Bring it on.* But Providence again smiled on Sam. Luther abruptly stopped, and snapped his head around. *More heartbeats.* Luther's undivided attention was diverted by human voices, and flickering lights moving in the distance. Alina saw the evil anticipation in his eyes.

"Please, Luther. Don't hurt anyone."

Sarcasm dripped from his foul, rank mouth. "I love humans. You know that." He despised them, but they were such a source of entertainment, and nourishment. "We both know you are much too weak to crawl to safety in time." He pointed to the shimmering sky and pierced her with another withering glare. "If you do not give me what I want by the time I return," he paused for effect, "I will leave you here." Fear was evident on Alina's face which pleased him. "That's right. Come to your senses, or perish."

As Luther eagerly entered the forest woods, a shadow high above flew after him. It went unnoticed by Alina whose 'fear' dissipated as quickly as it had appeared. It was nothing more than pretense. *I should have been an actress.*

Alina looked at Sam watching her from behind the tree. She weakly signaled for him to stay put. Alina listened intently for what seemed an eternity. She had to make sure Luther was out of hearing range, or this human male would meet with a violent and vicious end. Satisfied his safety was assured, Alina nodded for him to come forward.

Letting the tree branch slide to the forest floor with a muffled thump, Sam stepped out. His heart raced, but this time for an entirely different reason. It was accompanied by an empty nervousness, laced with a thrill churning deep within the pit of his stomach. Their eyes met with sustaining passion. His heart increased its unbridled pounding.

Sam wondered if she could hear his thumping heart. To him his pounding heart sounded louder than a beating bass drum. But the notion that she could actually hear it? *No way.* As he shook the thought off, a slight grin crossed her beautiful face. Her eyes shifted to his chest. *No way! Can she really hear my heart going nuts?* Yes, she could.

Alina's gaze shifted back to Sam's face. Their eyes locked in a time-melding moment of intimate, sizzling emotion. In that interlude of timelessness, though he couldn't hear her pulsating

heart, Sam sensed hers was matching his, beat for fervent beat. He wasn't wrong. She was taken by his charm. *He is a handsome human male.* Alina couldn't take her eyes off him.

Sam's mind swirled with confusing, yet wonderful thoughts. It felt as if a thousand fluttering butterflies had invaded his stomach. In a moment of time without beginning or end, the jolt of breathtaking true love struck them with an overflowing mix of anticipation, vulnerability and wild abandon. But while emotion overloaded his senses, deep within his mind a small voice began to penetrate with an urgency, which nagged him with persistent annoyance.

Reluctantly listening to that voice, reality roared back, returning Sam to the immediate present. Quickly taking stock of his surroundings, he lifted Alina by the waist, draping her over a shoulder upside down. Had she not been so fully clothed, Sam would have felt the coldness of her skin. But he was preoccupied with getting them safely out, so he may not have noticed anyway. Or if he had, Sam might have attributed the iciness of her skin to the chilly moon-filled night.

While he looked for the best direction in which to escape, Alina, in a weak voice, urged him to "Hurry!"

Sam, still searching for an exit route, replied, "I'm not sure which way I came in."

"That way. Hurry, you are in grave danger."

"You mean we, don't you?"

"No! I mean you! Please hurry!" The obvious concern in her voice alerted Sam, prompting him to assume a walk/run gait in the direction from which he had come. As her body bounced on his shoulder, Alina's naïve sense of humor surfaced in that instant of crisis. With her face inches from Sam's behind, she quipped, "Nice butt."

This brought a smile to Sam's face while he glanced at her perfect behind bouncing and rubbing against his cheek. "Back at you." He obviously could not see her blushing. As he broke into jogging mode, it suddenly hit him. Sam had finally chanced upon the girl he had to meet.